WESTON (*mightily flattered*): Nonsense, my good Roger, nonsense! Nothing is going to happen to me.

ROGER: I could perhaps go and warn the authorities, and so prevent –

WESTON (*very brave*): No, no, no. Am I to spend the rest of my life with a guard at my heels? Go on with your work and… (*his eye has lighted on a package which is lying on a chair against the right wall. The box is oblong – roughly 18 in. by 10 in. by 4 in. – and tied with cord. Sharply*) What is this?

ROGER: That came for you this morning, sir.

WESTON: What is it?

ROGER (*with the faint beginnings of doubt in his voice*): I don't know, my lord. A man came with it and said that it was important that you should have it to-day.

WESTON: And you didn't ask what it was! You fool!

ROGER (*humbly*): It didn't seem to be my business. I never do ask about the contents of your lordship's…. I showed your lordship the package when it came, and you said to leave it there.

WESTON (*peering with growing uneasiness at the thing*): The man who brought it, what did he look like? Was he small? Dark?

ROGER (*who obviously had taken no notice*): I think he was smallish. But as to dark – his hat was pulled over his face, I think - I think he appeared to have a mole on his chin, but I would not …. It may have been just a –

WESTON: A mole? (*his imagination at work*): A mole ! Yes. Yes. That man had a mole. The man who brushed against me. On the right side of his jaw. I can see it as if he were standing here. We must get rid of this. At once.

ROGER: Do you think it is some infernal machine, sir? What shall we do with it?

WESTON (*indicating the side window*): Open the window and I shall throw it as far into the garden as I can.

ROGER: But it may explode, sir, if we throw it.

WESTON: What is certain is that it will explode if we do not! How long has it been lying here?

ROGER: It came about nine o'clock, my lord.

WESTON (*in an agony*): Nearly three hours ago! Open the window, Roger.

ROGER: No, sir. You open the window. Let me handle the thing. My life is nothing. Yours is of great value to England.

WESTON: No, Roger, no. You are young. I have had my life. There are still great things for you to do in the world. You must live, and write my life for posterity. Do as I say. I promise you shall exercise the greatest care. (*As ROGER rushes to the window*) No. Wait. A better idea. The gardener's pail. It is still on the landing!

ROGER: Yes! Yes, of course! (*He is out of the room and back in a moment with the wooden pail of water, which still has the wet cleaning rag hung over its edge.*)

WESTON: Stand back. (*He picks up the parcel* ***gingerly***.) We do not know what may

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